Designing for diverse student needs

Do I design for common barriers?

EQUITY / CURRICULUM

ONE-PAGE TEACHING GUIDE

WHAT IS IT?

Course design reflects anticipated cohort needs, drawing on past and current enrolment data

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

The same course requirement can land very differently depending on time, money, care, disability, work, housing or confidence. Equity asks whether students with different lives have a real opportunity to participate and succeed, rather than simply receiving the same rule.

THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

- “This course assumes university is the only thing happening in my life.”
- “I can technically enrol, but the way this is organised makes participation fragile.”

HOW CAN I DO IT?

- Review common barriers from prior offerings and likely cohort patterns before the semester begins.
- Use those patterns to decide where early clarity, flexibility or scaffolding is most needed.
- Treat differences in cohort composition as design information, not anomalies.

EXAMPLE IN PRACTICE

A course with a large working-student cohort releases its full semester map before week 1 and reduces unnecessary on-campus spread.

STARTING POINT TO ADAPT

This course has been designed to design around common barriers experienced by students with different lives, resources and responsibilities.

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Inclusive practice

Online teaching